Small Grants, Big Opportunities: Enabling Inclusivity and Innovation in Digital Humanities

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In the rapidly evolving fields of humanities and cultural sciences, small grants – defined here as funding schemes offering modest financial support (often under €5,000), for short-term projects (1 – 6 month) – are key drivers of innovation, particularly in interdisciplinary research integrating digital methodologies.[1]

Unlike large-scale funding, they are characterized by minimal administrative burden and high flexibility. They can cover immediate research needs – such as software licenses, hiring short-term assistants, or technical infrastructure – and enable the swift testing of hypotheses, the rapid deployment of digital tools, and the exploration of unconventional approaches. Due to their accessible to early-career researchers, scholars from underrepresented institutions, or those pursuing non-traditional academic paths, small grants foster inclusivity and diversity in research. They are particularly crucial for disciplines or projects that often fall outside the scope of major funding calls. Yet despite these strengths and their clear alignment with the fast-paced demands of digital scholarship, small grants remain underutilized in the humanities and cultural sciences, where they could facilitate rapid methodological innovation and the integration of computational approaches into more traditional fields. Their potential is still not fully recognized in institutional strategies and funding policies.

In the German research landscape,[2] several small-grant programs have been established to support scholars working at the intersection of traditional and digital methods. These initiatives provide project-based funding to encourage collaboration, support Open Science, and promote the implementation of FAIR principles, all while minimizing bureaucratic hurdles. By providing the necessary resources, they enable scholars to push the boundaries of knowledge without the constraints of more rigid funding structures.

An example of such support is the Research Study Programme[3] of the HERMES Data Competence Center,[4] which provides funding for areas like data analysis, innovation, data preparation, and Open Science. By offering upfront financial support for immediate needs, including software acquisition, hiring research assistants, and other essential resources, it enables researchers to quickly advance their work. This immediacy is particularly crucial in the Digital Humanities, where access to the right tools and data can make or break a project. The program minimizes administrative barriers, allowing researchers to focus on practical outcomes, which promotes innovative and efficient research. Additionally, by fostering Open Science practices—such as preparing data for reuse—the program aligns with other initiatives like the FAIR Data Fellowships,[5] offered by NFDI4Memory, the consortium for the historically oriented humanities within the German National Research Data Infrastructure.[6] The fellowship program focuses on ensuring that research data, including those from dissertations and collaborative projects, can be published and reused in accordance with the FAIR principles. Researchers participating in these fellowships work remotely with expert guidance to ensure their data is prepared for broader academic purposes.

These funding programs reflect a growing commitment within the German research landscape to enhance accessibility, flexibility, and inclusivity in academia. With fewer bureaucratic barriers, small grants enable researchers from diverse backgrounds secure funding otherwise constrained by traditional structures. The outcomes of the first funding calls demonstrate their significant impact (Bärwald 2024, Prell et al. 2024). For instance, projects funded by HERMES have generated valuable datasets and research outputs, such as comprehensive reports, data documentation, and code repositories, like those from the MeAqua project (Mende et al. 2024). Similarly, the Moravians at Sea project has created an open-access platform to provide historical data, fostering broader academic collaboration (Prell 2025).[7]

These examples underscore how small grants facilitate the development of open-access resources, enhancing the visibility and accessibility of rese-

arch and advancing Digital Humanities. By supporting the creation of open-access platforms and promoting data reuse, these grants ensure transparency in research and encourage collaborative scholarship. Beyond financial or technical support, small grants serve as strategic investments in creativity and inclusivity, shaping the future direction of academic inquiry. The outcomes of the first funding calls illustrate how small grants foster international and interdisciplinary collaboration while enabling innovative research outputs. By highlighting these achievements, we can emphasize the tangible benefits of these funding models and encourage their broader adoption within the global Digital Humanities community.

To unlock their full impact, greater strategic recognition is needed of small grants as essential mechanisms for technical and methodological innovation, as well as for fostering inclusivity in digital humanities and related fields. Increasing their visibility will help democratize research, empower diverse voices, and overcome institutional barriers – ultimately promoting the flexibility and openness needed for truly innovative scholarship.

Notes

1. Author contributions (CRediT taxonomy): Constanze Buyken: Conceptualization, Investigation; Fabian Cremer: Conceptualization, Investigation; Judit Garzón Rodríguez: Conceptualization, Investigation, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.
2. A comparable initiative can be found in France, for instance, in Biblissima+ (e.g.,“Support for ‘Portal Innovation’” and “Support for exploratory projects”).
3. https://hermes-hub.de/forschen/forschungsstudien/forschungsstudien.html.
4. https://hermes-hub.de/.
5. https://4memory.de/4memory-fair-data-fellowships-2025/.
6. https://4memory.de/ ; https://www.nfdi.de/ . Another notable initiative is the NFDI4Objects Dataship, a three-month fellowship program during which creators prepare their datasets in alignment with FAIR principles, https://www.nfdi4objects.net . Another notable initiative is the NFDI4Objects Dataship, a three-month fellowship program during which creators prepare their datasets in alignment with FAIR principles.
7. https://www.moravians-at-sea.de/.

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